

Introduction to Human Sciences

Political Science Module

Comprehensive Lecture Notes

Lectures 1–4 — March 5–16, 2026

IIIT Hyderabad

Contents

1	What is Politics?	3
1.1	The Nature of Politics	3
1.2	Four Interpretations of Politics	3
1.2.1	1. Politics as the Art of Government	3
1.2.2	2. Politics as Public Affairs	4
1.2.3	3. Politics as Compromise and Consensus	4
1.2.4	4. Politics as Power	4
1.3	Theoretical vs. Applied Politics	5
2	The State	6
2.1	Definition and Components	6
2.2	Origin of the State	6
2.2.1	1. Divine Origin Theory	6
2.2.2	2. Social Contract Theory	7
2.3	What Should the State Do? (Five Models)	7
3	Government	9
3.1	Three Core Functions of Government	9
3.2	Types of Government	9
4	Liberty	11
4.1	Positive and Negative Freedom	11
5	Justice	12
5.1	Distributive Justice: The Flute Problem	12
5.2	Procedural Justice vs. Substantive Justice	12
6	Equality	14
6.1	The Equality Problem	14
6.2	Legal Equality	14
6.3	Models of Equality in Resource Allocation	15
7	Rights	16
8	Democracy and Citizenship	17
8.1	Democracy	17
8.2	Citizenship	17
9	Power, Authority, and Legitimacy	18
9.1	Power	18
9.2	Authority	18
9.3	Legitimacy	19
10	The Indian Constitution	20
10.1	Historical Context	20
10.2	The Preamble	20
10.3	Features of the Indian Constitution	21

10.4 The Union Executive	21
10.4.1 The President of India	21
10.4.2 The Prime Minister and Council of Ministers	22
10.5 The Parliament	23
10.5.1 Rajya Sabha (Upper House)	23
10.5.2 Lok Sabha (Lower House)	23
10.6 The Supreme Court of India	23
11 Summary: India's Constitutional Choices	25
12 Potential Exam Questions	26
12.1 Short Answer	26
12.2 Essay / Discussion	26

What is Politics?

Lecture 1 — March 5, 2026

The Nature of Politics

Politics (Broadest Sense)

Politics is the activity through which people **make**, **preserve**, and **amend** the general rules under which they live.

Key preliminary ideas:

- Politics is **not** restricted to governments or countries—it occurs in families, classrooms, workplaces, and every social group.
- Politics is an **essentially contested concept**: there is no single, universally accepted definition.
- **Aristotle** (the father of Political Science) argued that *“humans are by nature political animals.”*
 - By nature we tend to **differ** from one another.
 - When we differ, a **process** is required to arrive at decisions.
 - That process—whether in a family, a classroom, or a country—is politics.
- Aristotle also argued that politics is a **very ethical activity**—it is only through politics that a “good life” (a best possible arrangement of society) can be achieved.
- Aristotle called Political Science the **master science**: all other sciences may produce knowledge and technology, but politics ultimately decides *who gets what, when, and how*.

Four Interpretations of Politics

1. Politics as the Art of Government

Chancellor’s Definition

Politics is “an exercise of control within society through the making and enforcement of collective decisions.”

- Governing is an **art**, not a rigid science—there is no single “correct” way to govern.
- Not everyone can govern; it requires skills, imagination, attitude.
- **David Easton’s Systems Model**: Demands & support (inputs) → Political system → Laws, programs, taxes, enforcement, rejection of demands (outputs). Outputs feed back as new inputs.
- **Lord Acton**: “Power tends to corrupt, and absolute power corrupts absolutely.” (Corruption here means corruption of *ideas, values, faith*—not just bribery.)

Stoker's Observation

“Politics is designed to disappoint”—no decision can satisfy everyone. Outcomes are ambiguous, messy, and never final.

2. Politics as Public Affairs

- There is a distinction between the **public sphere** (where the state can make laws) and the **private sphere** (where it should not intervene).
- This boundary is **not fixed**—it changes across time, space, and cultural context.
- Examples of contested boundaries:
 - Should the state ban smoking? Liquor? Regulate data privacy?
 - Should the state make laws about how family members treat each other?
- **Feminist critique:** “The personal is political”—issues like domestic violence and marital rape, once considered “private,” are now recognized as matters requiring state intervention.

Public–Private Spectrum

- **Country A** (narrow public sphere): Only government apparatus is public; civil society, business, trade unions are private. State does not intervene much in economic activity.
- **Country B** (broad public sphere): Commerce, culture, art, cinema, books—everything is public. State can decide what is published, produced, or practiced.

3. Politics as Compromise and Consensus

- Focuses on the **process** by which decisions are made when people differ.
- Involves: compromise, conciliation, negotiation.
- Outcomes are always imperfect—a section of people will always be disappointed.
- Politics here is about **the way** decisions are made (as opposed to “public affairs,” which is about **the arena** in which they are made).

4. Politics as Power

Power

Power is the capacity to influence the decisions of others **without doing anything** (i.e., without overt force or coercion).

Three mechanisms through which power operates:

1. **Decision-Making:** Influencing the *content* of decisions. Who actually governs? Who has the ultimate control?

2. **Agenda-Setting:** Determining *what is discussed* and *what is not*. Controlling what people think is important.
3. **Thought Control:** Shaping what people *think, want, or need*—through ideological inoculation, psychological control, advertisements, propaganda.

Power ≠ Force

If you have to *do* something (use coercion, give orders, use violence) to get compliance, that is **force**, not power. True power means people comply *by default*.

Theoretical vs. Applied Politics

Theoretical Politics	Applied Politics
How did states originate?	How does politics actually function?
What is the nature of citizenship?	How do people navigate political systems?
What forms of institutions exist?	What gaps exist between theory and practice?
How are laws made & limited?	How is behavior shaped by technology, resources?
Predicting state behavior (IR)	How do people learn/unlearn political norms?

Two traditions in Political Science:

- **Philosophical tradition:** What *should* the best state/citizen/system look like?
- **Empirical tradition:** What *is* the reality? (e.g., Hobbes: humans are selfish—make laws for them as they are.)

Fundamental Question: Can Political Science Be Objective?

Unlike natural sciences, political scientists are emotionally invested in their subjects. We have personal histories, identities, and biases. Complete objectivity is nearly impossible—but critical, logical thinking is essential.

The State

Lecture 2 — March 9, 2026

Definition and Components

The State

A **state** is a political association that establishes **sovereign jurisdiction** within defined **territorial borders** and exercises authority through a set of **permanent institutions**.

The four essential components of a state:

1. **Territory**: A defined area, recognized by other states.
2. **Population**: People living within that territory.
3. **Government**: An entity that takes decisions and implements them (need not be democratic—can be military, monarchical, etc.).
4. **Sovereignty**: The supreme decision-making power. No external actor can impose decisions on a sovereign state.

India vs. Telangana

India satisfies all four components $\Rightarrow$ it is a **state**. Telangana has territory, population, and a government, but it does **not** have sovereignty (the central government can suspend a state government). Thus Telangana is an **administrative unit**, not a state in the political science sense. The term “state” for Indian sub-units is a historical legacy from 535+ princely states that merged to form the Union.

Permanent Institutions

Institutions like Parliament, the judiciary, and the Election Commission are **permanent**—individuals occupying positions change, but the institutions endure. These institutions are **public**: funded by public expenditure, responsible for collective governance.

Origin of the State

1. Divine Origin Theory

- Rulers are **chosen by God** and have unchallenged authority.
- The king is accountable **only to God**, not to the people.
- The king's word *is* the law.
- Succession is hereditary—the next in the royal line becomes king regardless of competence.
- People have **no right to rebel**; only God can punish the king.

- This theory supported **monarchical systems** for over 2,000 years.

2. Social Contract Theory

Social Contract

At some point in human history, a **voluntary agreement** (contract) was made: individuals gave up their right to use violence and agreed to share a portion of their production (taxes), in exchange for the state providing **security of life, liberty, and property**.

- People were living in a “state of nature” with constant conflict over land, property, and resources.
- To establish order, they created a **third-party institution** (the state).
- **What citizens give:** Right to use violence + share of income (taxes).
- **What the state provides:** Security, law and order, defense, justice.
- Different thinkers had different views of the “state of nature”:
 - **Hobbes:** Humans are selfish and brutish; life was “nasty, brutish, and short.” Absolute chaos required a strong sovereign.
 - **Locke:** Not total chaos, but self-interest could conflict with public interest. The state was needed to mediate.
- The social contract theory ultimately leads to **democracies** (“We the People...”).

Key Insight

If you start from the **divine origin** theory, you get monarchies. If you start from the **social contract**, you get democracies. The Indian Constitution begins: “We, the people of India... do hereby adopt, enact and give to ourselves this Constitution”—a clear social contract framing.

What Should the State Do? (Five Models)

1. **Minimal State:** Only provides law & order, police, judiciary, and defense. Everything else is private.
2. **Developmental State:** Intervenes in economic life to *promote* industrial growth (subsidized loans, land, incentives)—but the state itself does **not** produce or compete.
3. **Social-Democratic State:** Private players exist, *and* the state also participates in economic activity to ensure social justice, fairness, and equality (e.g., state-run schools in rural areas where private players won’t go).
4. **Collectivist State:** The **entirety** of economic life is under state control. No private players. State provides electricity, water, education, healthcare, etc. Rationale: private players seek profit; state seeks welfare.

5. **Totalitarian State:** State controls **all aspects of life**—not just economic, but also cultural, religious, personal, linguistic, educational.

Critical Thinking Exercise

Which model would you have chosen for India in 1947, and why? Different answers lead to fundamentally different political systems and lived experiences. This is why constitutions take years to write.

Government

Government

A **government** is a mechanism that has both the **capacity to take decisions** (legitimacy) and the **capacity to implement** those decisions.

Three Core Functions of Government

1. **Law-Making** (Legislature): Parliament makes laws following defined procedures.
2. **Implementation** (Executive): Ministries, bureaucracies, and officers implement the laws.
3. **Adjudication / Interpretation** (Judiciary): Courts interpret laws on a case-by-case basis—determining which laws apply, whether they have been violated, and what consequences follow.

Why Adjudication Matters

A law says “hurting someone’s sentiments is a crime.” When a specific case arises, the court must interpret: *Were* sentiments hurt? *Which* provisions apply? *What* punishment fits? This constant, case-by-case interpretation is crucial.

Types of Government

Type	Description
Absolute Monarchy	King/monarch has supreme, unchecked power.
Constitutional Monarchy	Monarch exists alongside an elected government; monarch’s power is limited (e.g., Bhutan, UK).
Parliamentary Democracy	Executive is responsible to the legislature . PM is leader of majority party in parliament (e.g., India, UK).
Presidential Democracy	Head of state is elected separately by the people. President appoints ministers who need not be legislators (e.g., USA).
Communism	Private property is abolished; state controls all means of production.
Socialism	Private property is allowed; state also actively participates in economic activity.
Aristocracy	Rule of the “best” (few families deemed to have superior wisdom/knowledge).
Oligarchy	Rule of the few; understood as a <i>corrupted</i> form of aristocracy where the few rule for self-interest (e.g., Russian oligarchs).
Dictatorship	Power seized (often via military); no democratic mandate (e.g., Myanmar).

Theocracy	State is run on the basis of religious beliefs; laws conform to religious practices (e.g., Afghanistan under Taliban).
Totalitarian	State controls <i>all</i> aspects of life—economic, cultural, personal (e.g., North Korea).
Colonialism	A foreign government controls your state.

Parliamentary vs. Presidential Democracy

- **Parliamentary:** You vote for a *legislator* (MP). The majority party's leader becomes PM. PM and ministers *must* be members of Parliament. Parliament can remove the PM via a **no-confidence motion**. PM needs parliamentary approval for every rupee collected or spent.
- **Presidential:** You vote *directly* for the President. President appoints ministers who need *not* be legislators. Separate mandate, separate election.

Liberty

Liberty

Liberty (freedom) requires three essential components:

1. **Notion of Choice:** Every freedom implies a choice (freedom to go to school = freedom to *not* go to school).
2. **Absence of Constraint:** No person, institution, cultural belief, or historical practice should prevent you from exercising that choice.
3. **Existence of Enabling Conditions:** Actual conditions must exist for you to exercise the choice (e.g., right to education is meaningless if there is no school, no transport, no nutrition).

Positive and Negative Freedom

Do Not Confuse with “Good” and “Bad”

Positive $\neq$ good. Negative $\neq$ bad. These terms describe the **role of the state**.

Negative Freedom	Positive Freedom
State stays out of it. “Freedom <i>from</i> ” interference. e.g., Freedom of speech (state cannot punish you for your expression). State makes broad rules and stays away.	State actively intervenes . “Freedom <i>to</i> ” achieve something. e.g., Right to education (state must build schools, provide teachers, ensure access). State provides funds, institutions, and direct support.

Culture and Liberty

- **Negative:** State says “I won’t interfere in your culture. Maybe I’ll give tax exemptions to cultural organizations, but I won’t actively promote anything.”
- **Positive:** State actively funds, subsidizes, and runs institutions to protect and promote culture. If it promotes *one* group’s culture → **monism**. If it promotes *all* groups’ cultures → **pluralism**.

Justice

Lectures 2 & 3 — March 9 & 12, 2026

Justice as a Resource Allocation Problem

Resources are **limited**; people who want them are **many**. The state must decide: *who gets what?* This creates the **justice problem**.

Distributive Justice: The Flute Problem

The Flute Problem (Amartya Sen)

There is **one flute** and three claimants:

- **Person A:** An expert flutist who has mastered the skill. Claims: “I can do the best with it.”
- **Person B:** Never got the opportunity to learn (due to socioeconomic conditions) but has immense interest and potential. Claims: “Give me the chance I was denied.”
- **Person C:** Doesn’t even *know what a flute is* because of extreme deprivation. Claims: “I need the most basic support.”

Who should get the flute? The answer depends on your theory of justice—merit, need, or equal opportunity.

Procedural Justice vs. Substantive Justice

Procedural Justice	Substantive Justice
Focus: Are the procedures fair?	Focus: Is the outcome fair?
Judge can <i>only</i> decide based on existing laws.	Judge can evaluate whether the law itself is fair.
Equal law for all; open & transparent proceedings; legal aid for those who cannot afford lawyers.	Judge examines the <i>merit</i> of the case beyond what the law literally says.
Today’s law applies to today’s crime (no retroactive application).	Allows judges to strike down unjust laws.
Problem: What if the law itself is unjust? (Slavery was legal. The Holocaust was legal. Apartheid was legal.)	Problem: Subjective judicial opinions may lead to inconsistent outcomes. Different judges, different results.
Followed by: India , UK	Followed by: USA

India's Model: Procedural + Judicial Review

India follows **procedural justice**—judges cite existing laws in every judgment. However, the Supreme Court has the power of **judicial review**: it can check whether the *process* of law-making was properly followed and whether any law violates the Constitution. If so, the Supreme Court can declare the law **null and void**. This is *not* the same as substantive justice—the court reviews procedure and constitutional compliance, not its own moral opinion.

Equality

Lecture 3 — March 12, 2026

The Equality Problem

Equality

Equality is **not** blanket uniformity (not “everyone wears the same uniform”). Equality is about **leveling down** the conditions that are crucial to human well-being, acknowledging that people are born into different socioeconomic backgrounds **they did not choose**.

- **Core question:** Are we born equal?
- **Modern democratic answer:** We are born equal in *dignity and rights*, but differences arise from socioeconomic backgrounds (gender, religion, region, language, caste, class).
- You have **no choice** in where you are born, but that birth determines your access to opportunities.
- Inequalities from **personal effort** (hard work, talent, dedication) $\neq$ equality problem.
- Inequalities from **birth circumstances** (no access to laptops, nutrition, healthcare) = equality problem for the state.

Reserved Metro Coaches for Women

Women face harassment in crowded public transport. Reserving a coach for women is **not** a violation of equality—it addresses a social reality that prevents women from accessing workplaces and schools. Reserving a coach for men (who don’t face this barrier) *would* violate equality.

How Equality Works

Imagine a scale: some people have more, some have less.

- State gives more to those who have **less** $\Rightarrow$ **promotes** equality.
- State gives more to those who already have **more** $\Rightarrow$ **violates** equality.

Legal Equality

- **Equality before the law:** The law treats every person as an individual, regardless of social background, religion, race, color, or gender.
- Justice should be **blind** to all factors except the evidence presented in court.
- A judge *cannot* say: “You’ve been guilty before, so you probably did it again.” Only evidence certified by the court is relevant.

- This principle is relatively recent (~200 years); historically, different laws applied to different social categories.

Models of Equality in Resource Allocation

1. **Equality of Opportunity** (“Right to be unequal”): The state ensures that disadvantaged groups get support at the **entry level** so they can compete on a level playing field. Once the opportunity is provided, outcomes may differ based on individual effort.
2. **Equality of Outcome**: The state ensures that **results** are equal, regardless of starting point. (India has **not** adopted this model.)
3. **Equality of Capabilities** (Amartya Sen): Focus on ensuring people have equal **capabilities**—the real freedoms to achieve what they value.

India’s Model

India follows **equality of opportunity** and **equality of status**. The Constitution abolishes titles (except academic/military) to ensure no human being is deemed superior to another by birth.

Rights

Lecture 3 — March 12, 2026

Rights

Rights are claims or entitlements that individuals have on others. Every right comes with an **obligation** (for others to respect and enable that right).

Negative Rights	Positive Rights
Right to be free from interference.	Right to receive something from the state.
e.g., Right to property, freedom of speech.	e.g., Right to education, right to employment.
State must not interfere.	State must actively provide .

Fundamental Rights in India

Fundamental rights are given to citizens **against the government**. The government cannot violate these rights. You do not get “right to equality” inside your family—that is a different domain. Fundamental rights constrain *state* behavior toward citizens.

Democracy and Citizenship

Lecture 3 — March 12, 2026

Democracy

Democracy

A system of government in which power is held by the people, either **directly** or through **elected representatives**.

Two foundational assumptions of democracy:

1. All individuals are **equal**.
2. All individuals are **rational**.

Three fundamental questions every democracy must answer:

1. **Who are “the people”?** (Who gets to participate?)
2. **How should they rule?** (Electoral systems: first-past-the-post, proportional representation, etc.)
3. **How far should their rule extend?** (Limits of democratic authority.)

Democracy vs. Republic

Democracy: People elect their representatives. **Republic:** The *head of state* is also elected (not hereditary). India is **both**—the President is indirectly elected. The UK is a democracy but **not** a republic (the head of state is a monarch).

Citizenship

Citizenship

The legal, political, and social relationship between an individual and a state.

Three dimensions of citizenship:

1. **Legal Status:** A citizen has a legal claim to all constitutional and parliamentary rights. The government cannot exclude citizens from fundamental rights. However, this does *not* necessarily mean participation in law-making (e.g., apartheid South Africa: laws applied to all, but people of color had no say in making them).
2. **Political Participation:** Citizens are **political agents**—they actively participate in the state’s political institutions (voting, running for office, engaging in political processes).
3. **Personal Identity:** Being a citizen of a country forms part of your **identity**. It creates a sense of **affinity** (e.g., feeling connection with fellow Indians abroad, pride during the national anthem).

Power, Authority, and Legitimacy

Lecture 3 — March 12, 2026

Power

Power (Robert Dahl)

“Power involves A getting B to do something that B would otherwise not do.”

- Power is **relational**—it always involves at least two actors (“A is powerful *relative to* B”).
- It does not exist in isolation.
- To become powerful, you need: **resources, capabilities, structures and institutions**.
- In **domestic politics**: Power is associated with occupying positions of **authority** (you follow a traffic policeman because they have authority; you wouldn’t stop for a random person).
- In **international relations** (Realism): Power is associated with **military capabilities**.
- **Soft Power**: Influence through non-coercive means—culture, ideology, brands, media. (Examples: South Korea recognized through K-pop/Korean culture; India recognized through yoga/Bollywood.)

Authority

Authority

The right to be obeyed, or the necessity to have one’s decisions obeyed, **without** the need for coercion or persuasion.

- A thief may threaten you into giving money (force). A con artist may trick you (persuasion). **Neither has authority.**
- The government asks you to pay 10% income tax—it *has* the authority to do so.

Three types of authority (Max Weber):

1. **Legal-Rational Authority**: Derived from being elected through constitutional processes. Has a defined tenure (e.g., 5 years). After the tenure, disobeying is not a criminal offence.
2. **Traditional Authority**: Based on cultural, religious, or historical institutions that people believe in and follow.
3. **Charismatic Authority**: Based on personal loyalty, admiration, or devotion to a leader (celebrities, religious leaders, political figures).

Legitimacy

Legitimacy

Legitimacy consists of two components:

1. **Legal right to authority:** Having the legal/constitutional backing.
2. **Valid recognition by others:** Others must *accept* and *acknowledge* that authority.

- A traffic policeman has *both*: legal authority *and* your recognition. A random person has neither.
- The legal right can exist *without* recognition (e.g., apartheid South Africa: the white government had legal authority, but people of color never recognized it as legitimate).
- In **international politics**, legitimacy is crucial for justifying actions (e.g., the 2003 Iraq War was justified through the UN Security Council on the grounds of “weapons of mass destruction”—which were never found).

The Indian Constitution

Lecture 4 — March 16, 2026

Historical Context

- The Indian Constitution must be understood in the context of the **Indian Freedom Movement**—a ~200-year struggle against British colonial rule.
- Unlike many freedom struggles, the Indian movement was **forward-looking**: it did not promise to restore a pre-colonial system (500+ mostly monarchical states). It promised a **functional democracy**.
- Many democratic institutions (Federal Court → Supreme Court, two houses of Parliament, PM and ministers) were **experimented with during British rule** itself (from 1909 onwards).
- The Constitution reflects the **promises made during the freedom movement**—shared convictions about what independent India would look like.
- Both **text** (what it says) and **context** (why it says it) matter.

The Preamble

The Preamble of the Indian Constitution

“We, the people of India, having solemnly resolved to constitute India into a **Sovereign Socialist Secular Democratic Republic** and to secure to all its citizens:

- **Justice**—social, economic, and political;
- **Liberty**—of thought, expression, belief, faith, and worship;
- **Equality**—of status and of opportunity;

and to promote among them all **Fraternity** assuring the **dignity of the individual** and the **unity and integrity of the Nation**;

In our Constituent Assembly this twenty-sixth day of November, 1949, do hereby adopt, enact and **give to ourselves** this Constitution.”

Key analysis of the Preamble:

- “**We the people**”—not God, not the British, not the Constituent Assembly. The people give the Constitution to themselves. This is a **social contract** framing.
- No provision exists to declare this Constitution invalid from outside—it cannot be “taken back.”
- **Sovereign**: No external interference in India’s decision-making. India rejected “dominion status” (which would keep the British monarch as symbolic head of state).
- **Socialist** and **Secular**: These words were added to the Preamble in the 1970s, but the *provisions* already existed since 1950.

- **Secular** (Indian interpretation): The state does not discriminate among religions. State *can* interfere in religious practices (e.g., ban practices against scientific temper). Religion *cannot* interfere in state matters (no religious approval needed for laws).
- **Democratic Republic**: Democratic = people elect representatives. Republic = head of state (President) is also elected (indirectly), not hereditary.
- **Justice**: Social, economic, and political—addressing the resource allocation problem through multiple dimensions.
- **Liberty**: Of thought, expression, belief, faith, and worship.
- **Equality of status**: All titles abolished (except academic/military). No human being is superior by birth.
- **Equality of opportunity**: India chose opportunity-level equality, **not** outcome-level equality.
- **Fraternity**: Assuring **dignity of the individual** (the first human right in international human rights documents) and unity/integrity of the nation.

Features of the Indian Constitution

1. **Written Constitution**: Unlike the UK (which follows conventions), India has a written, codified document.
2. **Longest Constitution in the world**: ~400 articles + schedules (cf. US Constitution: 7 articles). Detailed provisions for almost every conceivable scenario.
3. **“Beautiful Patchwork”**: Draws from various global sources—no claim to unique originality. Ideas from the UK, US, France, Ireland, and others were adapted to the Indian context.
4. **Federal system with a unitary bias**: Power is divided between center and states, but the central government has more powers (can suspend state governments, control certain subjects exclusively).
5. **Separation of Powers**: Legislature (Parliament), Executive (PM + Ministers), Judiciary (Supreme Court + High Courts)—with checks and balances.
6. **Fundamental Rights**: Constitutional guarantees against the state (right to equality, freedom of speech/expression, protection against arbitrary arrest, etc.).
7. **Directive Principles of State Policy**: Non-justiciable guidelines for the government in making laws and policies—aspirational goals for social/economic justice.
8. **Independent Judiciary**: The judiciary can interpret the Constitution, review laws, and protect fundamental rights.

The Union Executive

The President of India

- **Head of State** (ceremonial role).

- Indirectly elected (by an electoral college of MPs and MLAs).
- Acts on the **aid and advice** of the Council of Ministers headed by the PM.
- **Cannot** make independent orders—all orders must come from the PM/Council of Ministers.
- **Cannot reject** the PM's advice—can only **hold/delay** decisions.
- If the President delays for too long, Parliament can initiate **impeachment**.
- Has access to the **Contingency Fund of India** for emergencies (but must get parliamentary approval within a month and replenish the fund).
- The President does *not* decide who becomes PM—that is determined by the Constitution (leader of the majority party/coalition in Lok Sabha).

The Prime Minister and Council of Ministers

- PM is the **Head of Government** (executive power).
- PM is appointed by the President (but must be the leader of the majority in Lok Sabha).
- PM **chooses** the Council of Ministers; the President merely appoints them on PM's advice.
- Ministers must be **members of Parliament** (Lok Sabha or Rajya Sabha). If not a member at the time of appointment, must gain membership within **6 months**.
- Total ministers cannot exceed **15%** of the total members of the house.
- PM is **Chairman of the Cabinet**—decides the agenda of cabinet meetings.
- PM is the **chief advisor** to the President.
- PM handles international relations, coordinates all ministries, and is the head of India's **Nuclear Command Authority**.

Two Key Principles

1. **Collective Responsibility:** There is *no* individual ministerial responsibility. All ministers sink or swim together. If you disagree with a government decision, you must **resign**—you cannot dissent while staying in the ministry.
2. **Principle of Secrecy:** Certain matters (defense, taxation, etc.) require confidentiality. Ministers take an **oath of secrecy**.

Balance of Power: President vs. PM

The President cannot act independently, and the PM cannot sign orders—a deliberate **check and balance**. The President must agree with the PM's advice (can delay, not reject). The PM must report all cabinet decisions to the President. Neither has absolute power.

The Parliament

Rajya Sabha (Upper House)

- **Permanent body**—never dissolved. (Ensures continuity even if Lok Sabha is dissolved.)
- Members serve **6-year terms**; one-third retire every 2 years (staggered elections).
- **Indirect election**: Members of State Legislative Assemblies vote for Rajya Sabha members.
- Presiding officer: **Vice-President of India**.
- Quorum: 1/10th of members.
- Minimum age: **30 years**.

Lok Sabha (Lower House)

- Represents the **people of India** directly.
- Tenure: **5 years** (dissolved after each term; fresh elections).
- Election: **First-past-the-post** system with **universal adult franchise** (all citizens above a certain age can vote).
- Minimum age: **25 years**.
- Lok Sabha can bring a **no-confidence motion** against the government.
- All **financial legislation** (budget) must be approved by Parliament—PM cannot collect or spend even one rupee without parliamentary approval.
- Parliament controls the executive: can ask questions, demand information, and hold ministers accountable.

Parliamentary Privileges

Members have **absolute freedom of expression** inside the house—they cannot be tried for anything said during proceedings. This protects against the risk of members being silenced on important issues. Members also have protection from arrest during sessions to prevent manipulation of voting.

The Supreme Court of India

Three jurisdictions:

1. **Original Jurisdiction**: Any matter of **constitutional interpretation** goes directly to the Supreme Court. If a constitutional question arises in a lower court, it is transferred to the Supreme Court.
2. **Appellate Jurisdiction**: If dissatisfied with a High Court decision, parties can appeal to the Supreme Court.
3. **Advisory Jurisdiction**: The President can seek the Supreme Court's opinion on legal/constitutional matters.

Key powers and features:

- **Guardian of the Constitution:** Can review laws and administrative actions. If a parliamentary law contradicts the Constitution, the Supreme Court can declare it **null and void**.
- **Court of Record:** All Supreme Court proceedings are permanently recorded and can be **cited** as precedent in lower courts.
- **Judicial Activism / Suo Motu:** The court can initiate proceedings *on its own* if an important public concern arises, even without a petition.
- **Public Interest Litigation (PIL):** A unique feature—if someone's rights are being violated but they lack the means/knowledge to approach the court, **any person** can file on their behalf.
- **Basic Structure Doctrine:** The government cannot amend the Constitution in a way that alters its **basic structure** (including fundamental rights). Even with the highest majority, Parliament cannot change the fundamental rights framework.

Summary: India's Constitutional Choices

Concept	India's Interpretation
Origin of State	Social Contract (“We the people... give to ourselves this Constitution”)
Type of State	Social-Democratic (private players + state participation)
Type of Government	Parliamentary Democracy (executive responsible to legislature)
Republic	Yes —President is elected (indirectly), not hereditary
Justice Model	Procedural + Judicial Review (not substantive)
Equality Model	Equality of opportunity + Equality of status
Liberty	Mix of positive and negative freedoms (6 fundamental rights)
Secularism	State does not discriminate among religions; can regulate religious practices; religion cannot interfere in state
Federalism	Federal with unitary bias —center is stronger than states
Judiciary	Independent ; guardian of Constitution; judicial review; PIL; suo motu

Potential Exam Questions

Short Answer

1. Define politics. Why is it called an “essentially contested concept”?
2. What are the four components of a state? Explain with examples.
3. Distinguish between public and private affairs in politics. Give an example where the boundary has shifted over time.
4. Define power. How is it different from force?
5. What are the three mechanisms through which power operates?
6. Explain the social contract theory of the origin of the state.
7. What are the three essential components of liberty?
8. Distinguish between positive and negative freedom with examples.
9. What is the difference between procedural and substantive justice? Which model does India follow?
10. Define equality. Why is it not the same as uniformity?
11. Distinguish between equality of opportunity and equality of outcome.
12. What are the three dimensions of citizenship?
13. Define authority. What are Weber’s three types?
14. What is legitimacy? What are its two components?
15. What is India’s interpretation of secularism?

Essay / Discussion

1. Discuss the four interpretations of politics. Which do you find most compelling and why?
2. Compare the divine origin theory and the social contract theory of the state. How do they lead to fundamentally different political systems?
3. Analyze the five models of “what should the state do.” Which model did India adopt and why?
4. “The personal is political.” Discuss this feminist argument in the context of the public–private distinction.
5. Discuss the Preamble of the Indian Constitution. How does it reflect the promises of the freedom movement?
6. Analyze the system of checks and balances between the President and Prime Minister of India.
7. Discuss the role of the Supreme Court as the “guardian of the Constitution.”

8. Explain the justice problem as a resource allocation problem using the Flute Problem.
9. “Politics is designed to disappoint.” Critically analyze this statement.
10. Discuss the relationship between power, authority, and legitimacy with examples from domestic and international politics.